

Networking for a Job Search

You have likely already heard plenty about the important role networking and relationship building play in career development, but you are far less likely to have heard guidance about how to initiate new contacts or to prepare for networking situations.

Initiating networking contacts:

Initiating contact with those you don't know is fairly straightforward, but there are many nuances that increase your chances of receiving a positive response and making a productive connection. To initiate contact, send a concise email to introduce yourself, briefly describe your background and goals, identify the reason for reaching out, and request approximately 10-15 minutes of your potential contact's time.

Best Practices:

- Reach out by email before calling someone as people don't like to be caught off guard.
- Clearly identify who you are and why you are reaching out; what goal are you looking to accomplish in connecting?
- Be formal, but not too formal in your communication. Do not write the email as if it were a cover letter. While your end goal may be to have the individual help you get a job, your initial goal should largely be to gather information and make a new contact.
- To that end, DO NOT attach your resume in your initial email. If the potential contact agrees to review and/or forward your resume as a next step after the conversation, that is great, but it can be a bit off-putting to receive a resume out of the blue.
- Propose a "call to action" at the end of the email (e.g., give a few times over the next week or two that you are available for a call, or ask for their availability).
- Don't ask for more than 15 minutes of someone's time. Everyone's time is precious and putting boundaries on the call makes it more palatable for your contact.
- Be patient; while you are conducting your job search with the utmost level of urgency, the people on the other side of the email don't have that same sense of immediacy.
- If you haven't heard back after a week or two, don't be afraid to follow up with a friendly email, proposing new times to chat and reiterating your interest in your contact's field / job function.

Things that people often get wrong or forget:

- Asking for something too general, such as "learning more about your firm."
- Asking for too much given the newness of the contact. Examples include: company information that would be inappropriate to share with someone unfamiliar, a job recommendation, or a referral to others in the person's network.

- Engaging in too much outreach at once and being unable to respond in a timely manner, or not following up at all.
- Not conducting preliminary research about the industry, function, company, and/or contact.
- Not preparing for the networking conversation.

Preparing for networking events:

A networking event can take many forms—it can range from an informal coffee meeting to a speaker panel to a formal professional association or alumni event. No matter which format in which it occurs, a networking event is an opportunity to:

- Make connections
- Build strategic relationships with key people in your target sector/function
- Share information
- Tap into the ‘hidden’ job market
- Increase your visibility and
- Generate a favorable impression

The most successful networkers focus on whom they want to target and why they want to meet that specific individual. To establish a more meaningful connection, it is important to prepare and plan:

- Obtain a list of participants that will be attending the event (if available).
- Target the people you would like to meet (if not by name, then by target company and role).
- Research attending companies—their key products/services, the names of their top executives, their competitors, industry trends/dynamics and current news stories. While conducting your research, develop succinct statements about why you are attracted to each firm/why you want to meet with each individual.
- Comb your network (Alumni Directory, friends, family, professional networks, LinkedIn, etc.) to find out if you already have any mutual connections with other attendees.

Plan for the flow of the event:

- Prepare your story and rehearse it to make it sound natural, confident, and smooth. Be creative —think of something that makes you stand out, helps break the ice, and entices a conversation.
- Update your LinkedIn profile — people are likely to ‘check’ your online presence.
- Dress appropriately; bring your business cards and a pen.
- Brush up on ‘social’ conversation topics.
- Have a few polite exit strategies.

At the event:

- Arrive early — the later you walk in the harder it is to meet people as they may already be engaged in conversations.
- Avoid gravitating towards the people you already know . . . remember you are at the event to meet new people so introduce yourself to someone new.
- Scope out the layout / high traffic areas to gauge the best locations for meeting people.
- Determine your game plan — prioritize whom you wish to meet but be flexible.

Networking is about cultivating relationships, establishing rapport, and trust to make the best impression:

- Demonstrate confidence with good eye contact and a firm handshake. When joining a conversation make eye contact with whoever is speaking so you are invited into the group — never interrupt.
- Engage your audience — show genuine interest in the people you are talking to. Give them your attention — there is nothing worse than someone looking over your shoulder when you are talking to them.
- Develop well-prepared introductions / questions; weave details about your background and credentials fluidly into a conversation. Tell people something that will help them remember you.
- Listen and ask open questions — ‘discover’ how you can add value to/ assist the other person.
- Personalize the conversation — find a common ground such as shared interests/connections like sports, activities, or people.
- Contacts are more likely to remember you if you personalize the encounter.
- Know when to stop talking and move on. More face time does not mean a better impression — watch for non-verbal cues — if you pick up on the vibe that someone doesn’t want to talk to you anymore say, “It was great to meet you” and move on.
- Move around — it’s difficult to meet people if you are sitting down or ‘rooted’ to one spot.
- Write on the back of contacts’ cards to help you remember key parts of the conversation or actions you commit to.
- Treat everyone with respect — introduce others, be courteous and respectful. Maintaining a healthy sense of humor also helps with varied communication styles.

After the event:

How many times have you gone to an event, had excellent conversations, exchanged business cards with the intention of ‘staying in touch,’ but then you get back to work, you are swamped, and soon the business cards end up at the bottom of your drawer and the connections you made become a distant memory? Following up is the most important part of networking:

- ALWAYS follow up — even if it is just a ‘good to meet you’ email within 48hrs.

- Deliver on any commitments — networking is based on trust.
- Be patient and persistent. Networking takes time and effort — just sending one e-mail after meeting someone is not going to build a long-term relationship; you need to invest time and energy into the relationship. If you don't receive a response, try sending another email in two weeks.
- Stay connected — employers prefer to hire people they know over complete strangers, and headhunters will reach out to those they have a relationship with.

Resources:

Online:

- Alumni = Career Services > Changing Companies, Functions, and Industries > Networking
- E/W = Careers > Market & Prepare Yourself > Prepare to Network

Books (Fisher Career Resource Center):

- Networking Like a Pro: Turning Contacts into Connections – Ivan R. Misner, David G. Alexander, and Brian Hiliard
- Networking Like a Rockstar – Jaymin Patel
- Social Networking for Career Success: Using Online Tools to Create a Personal Brand – Miriam Salpeter

CareerCast (<https://www.chicagobooth.edu/careercast>)

- Building Enduring Relationships for Career Success – Kurt Mortensen
- Unpack the Fear of Connecting – Gloria Petersen
- Relationships: Purposeful, Passionate, and Practical – Guy Kawasaki

Other

- Questions? Contact Career Services by email at boothworks@ChicagoBooth.edu or by calling 312-464-8677.